



Yungblud played on Mars

Yungblud's cover of David Bowie's *Life On Mars* was played by NASA's Perseverance Rover as it landed. <http://digit.in/mar21-57>



Civilian Space Mission

Hayley Arceneaux becomes the first bone cancer survivor, and youngest American to orbit the Earth. <http://digit.in/mar21-58>

Not another one!

Boo Man thinks Mars rovers are a terrible idea...

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We can't help it can we? All of us who are interested in science and technology. All of us in the Digit family. I'm talking about our unhealthy obsession with space of course, and how it sends us all into a tizzy. A billion of us were watching with bated breath as India's missions to Mars and the Moon took off, and then completed. But let's face it, we're not good marketers like the Americans.

On the 18th of February 2021, at some ungodly hour of the night for us (making it technically 19th of Feb for us), NASA was live-streaming mission control's reactions to the final landing sequence of the Perseverance Rover mission that they sent to Mars. I'd love to claim to be an intellectual who stayed awake specifically to experience the thrill of humanity landing yet another object on a planetary body that is not our home... but the fact of the matter is, I happened to be awake. I was half working, half watching random people livestream themselves playing games. Yes, this is the sad reality that I find myself living in. Not only am I so lazy that I sit awake watching YouTube at night, I'm also becoming too lazy to even have fun by playing a game! Let someone else do the work of playing the game while I watch aimlessly!

As usual, I digress, but I swear I have a point to make... eventually.

Bear with me while I figure out how to get to it.

So what on Mars is my reason for writing a hate column about a rover the whole world should love? One aspect of that is definitely this vicarious living that we seem to be driving ourselves to. Many science fiction authors have explored this aspect in their writing. To put it bluntly, humans are too fragile and useless for space journeys. Robots and rovers and AI-driven gadgets are just so much more efficient and cheaper to send off to places far, far away. Our entire legacy of being explorers, being pioneers, and just living out the human condition of "going where no man had gone before" seems to be fading. And look, it probably isn't and there are probably thousands of scientists working in space agencies and companies around the world, who would scoff at the idiocy of that statement I made, but I made it anyway, and with what I think is a good reason.

When did the human race become a helicopter parent that's padding us up, trying to prevent us from getting hurt, and using hand sanitizer all the time! (Used to be a pre-covid time when that last bit was a valid joke one would make about helicopter parents...).

I guess what I mean is that NASA and everyone else involved with space travel are being super cautious and losing the desire to take risks, to allow eager humans to risk their own lives, in an attempt to be the people to go to Mars and beyond. So many people on Earth die needlessly every day anyway, as do soldiers and civilians in pointless wars, and many of those would bite your hand off for a chance to go to space, no matter the risk.

Instead, we're sitting here looking at a rover that will do things in its

lifetime of years, something a human could do in a matter of weeks or days if only we could get them there!

Thanks to COVID-19, the entire world has pretty much got a lesson in sitting at home, and while that's horrible for most, there are enough and more people who didn't mind the confinement at all! An ever increasing number of people, mostly youngsters, are extremely happy to live life through a screen. This is because a very large number of people who live in a more urban setting spend more time online via phones, laptops and PCs than they do out in the real world. And who can blame them? The world is crowded, dirty, noisy and pretty horrible compared to the beautiful worlds and beautiful people that we see inside our screens.

And there's something even worse! With the constant improvements in technology and the capability of computers, the make believe worlds in our screens actually look a lot better than the actual footage of new worlds... The movies are making us immune to the wonderment of simple visuals, which I felt was apparent when watching the videos that NASA released, from so many different angles, of Perseverance landing on the surface of Mars. Those videos are stunning, and science nerds could spend days watching and rewatching the few minutes of footage of the landing. And yet, many seemed to take those visuals very matter of factly.

As awesome an achievement it is to land an SUV-sized rover on a planet 200-something million km away from us, I sincerely hope we start focusing on manned missions to Mars soon. Though with our luck, it will probably be planned and executed reality TV style... Survivor Mars? Could be fun! 